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Ezekiel

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Ezekiel

A. Summary and Overview.

1. The book of Ezekiel was written by the prophet and priest Ezekiel (Vs. 1:3) between 592 and 565 BC. He was a contemporary of Daniel and Jeremiah and was among the first wave of exiles taken to Babylon when Jerusalem was first conquered in 597 BC. The city was spared, but Ezekiel and other captives, including Daniel, King Jeconiah and other citizens of nobility, were taken to Babylon. The book of Ezekiel is one of the major prophetic books of the Bible, along with Isaiah, Daniel and Jeremiah. Jeremiah wrote from Jerusalem while Ezekiel wrote from Babylon.
2. Ezekiel was 25 when he was first taken to Babylon. At age 30, he is by the Chebar canal in Babylon when the first vision of the Lord comes to him (Vs. 1:4). The book can be divided into three major sections: 1) Prophecies against Judah and Jerusalem, chapters 1-24; 2) Prophecies against the foreign nations, chapters 25-32 and 3) Prophecies of hope and salvation, chapters 33-48.
3. As the book is lengthy, key verses and summaries will be used to present its content.

B. Chapter 1 recounts Ezekiel's call as a prophet. He is sitting by the Chebar canal when God appears in His glory. The vision is of four living creatures having the likeness of men but with faces of not only humans, but of creatures including a cherubim, lion, ox and eagle. They had wings which touched each other but also covered their bodies. Beside the creatures were wheels which without turning allowed the creatures to move in any direction. Above the creatures was an expanse like crystal, and above the expanse was a throne like sapphire, and on the throne was a likeness of a human with fire and brightness all around. Ezekiel falls on his face and hears the voice of one speaking.

C. Chapter 2 tells that the voice says to him: "Son of man, I send you to the people of Israel, to nations of rebels, who have rebelled against me. They and their fathers have transgressed against me to this very day" (Vs. 2:3). A hand reaches out and gives him a scroll upon which was written words of lamentation, mourning and woe (Vs. 2:10b).

D. Chapter 3 describes how God instructs him to eat the scroll. The glory of the Lord then carries him away to the exiles along the canal.

E. Chapter 4 records some unusual acts the Lord required of Ezekiel. He first builds a model of the city of Jerusalem and then is instructed to lie on his left side 390 days for the punishment of Israel, and then 40 days on his right side for Judah. Each day representing a year for a total of 430 days which some scholars believe is a reminder of the 430-year sojourn in Egypt. During this time, he is bound and must cook a mixture of grains and lentils over a fire made from cow dung. The amount of water is also prescribed. All of this is to represent the restrictions of food and water and manner of cooking during the siege of Jerusalem.

F. Chapter 5 describes how the Lord required Ezekiel to cut his hair and divide it into three parts to represent the judgement that will be passed upon Jerusalem. It also recounts the Lord's vexation against Jerusalem for her sin and idolatry.

G. Chapters 6 through 9 continue the description of the outpouring of God's wrath. In chapter 8, he is given a vision of the abominations of idolatry in the temple by men and women worshiping false idols. Chapter 9 describes a vision where the idolaters are killed.

H. Chapter 10 returns to the vision first given to Ezekiel of the glory of the Lord. He sees in this vision the glory leaving the temple in Jerusalem.

I. Chapter 11 contains a promise of eventual restoration of Israel: "Therefore say, 'Thus says the Lord GOD: I will gather you from the peoples and assemble you out of the countries where you have been scattered, and I will give you the land of Israel.' And when they come there, they will remove from it all its detestable things and all its abominations. And I will give them one heart, and a new spirit I will put within them. I will remove the heart of stone from their flesh and give them a heart of flesh, that they may walk in my statutes and keep my rules and obey them. And they shall be my people, and I will be their God" (Vs. 11:16-20).

J. Chapter 12 relates how Ezekiel is instructed to dig through a wall and carry luggage out at night. This represents how Zedekiah, king of Jerusalem, will attempt to escape the Chaldeans. It also predicts his capture and his being taken to Babylon, but "he will not see it and die there". When captured, Zedekiah's eyes were put out and he indeed died in Babylon but did not see it (Vs 12:13).

K. Chapters 13 and 14 are a condemnation by the Lord against false prophets and idolatrous elders.

L. Chapters 15 and 16 compare Jerusalem to a useless vine and a faithless bride.

M. Chapter 17 is a parable of two eagles and two trees. One depicts Zedekiah who trusted in Egypt but was destroyed. The other depicts the future Messiah who will bear fruit to the Lord.

N. Chapter 18 is a discussion by the Lord of His justice in judging sin: “Therefore I will judge you, O house of Israel, every one according to his ways, declares the Lord GOD. Repent and turn from all your transgressions, lest iniquity be your ruin. Cast away from you all the transgressions that you have committed, and make yourselves a new heart and a new spirit! Why will you die, O house of Israel? For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live (Vs. 18:3-32).”

O. Chapter 19 is a lamentation against the princes of Israel.

P. Chapter 20 recounts Israel’s continuing rebellion but gives a promise of future restoration: “As I live, declares the Lord GOD, surely with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm and with wrath poured out I will be king over you. I will bring you out from the peoples and gather you out of the countries where you are scattered, with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm, and with wrath poured out” (Vs. 20:33-34).

Q. Chapter 21 continues God’s outpouring of future wrath against Jerusalem as a sword, but also against the Ammonites.

R. Chapter 22 continues the Lord’s recounting of Israel’s sins.

S. Chapter 23 is an allegory of two sisters: “As for their names, Oholah is Samaria, and Oholibah is Jerusalem” (Vs. 32:4b). They are compared to lewd prostitutes, and prophecy of their destruction is given.

T. Chapter 24 relates how the siege of Jerusalem began. The Lord tells Ezekiel that his wife will die, but that he is not to mourn. He is given instructions how to dress and what to do so that those Jews in Babylon will do likewise when Jerusalem falls. He is told that a fugitive will come and relate Jerusalem’s fall.

U. Chapter 25 contains prophecies against Ammon, Moab, Seir, Edom and Philistia.

V. Chapter 26 contains a detailed prophecy against Tyre: “I will make you a bare rock. You shall be a place for the spreading of nets. You shall never be rebuilt, for I am the LORD; I have spoken, declares the Lord GOD” (VS. 26:14). Bible critics point out that today, Lebanon has been rebuilding the city and it now has a population of 135,000 calling this a false prophecy. However, it is useful to review its history. Tyre has two parts, a mainland and a small island separated from the mainland by a strait of about 540 yards. King Nebuchadnezzar destroyed the mainland city in 585 to 573 BC but, was unable to destroy the island. It was not until Alexander the Great that the island was taken. He took rubble from the destruction of the mainland and built a causeway to the island destroying the city and killing 8,000 men. The city was never rebuilt to its full glory that it had at the time of this prophecy as a commercial empire, world trader and colonizer. It became a bare rock for the spreading of nets. Even today, the town is but a shadow of its former glory.

W. Chapter 27 is a lament against Tyre and describes its former glory.

X. Chapter 28 begins with a lament over the king of Tyre, but changes into a prophecy of the judgement of Satan: “You were the signet of perfection, full of wisdom and perfect in beauty. You were in Eden, the garden of God; every precious stone was your covering, sardius, topaz, and diamond, beryl, onyx, and jasper, sapphire, emerald, and carbuncle; and crafted in gold were your settings and your engravings. On the day that you were created they were prepared. You were an anointed guardian cherub. I placed you; you were on the holy mountain of God; in the midst of the stones of fire you walked. You were blameless in your ways from the day you were created, till unrighteousness was found in you” (Vs. 28:12b-15).

Y. Chapters 29 through 32 describe prophecies against Egypt. Jerusalem had appealed to Egypt for aid during the siege by Babylon. Pharaoh Hophra brought an army to Jerusalem in the spring of 588 which caused the Babylonians to temporarily lift the siege as noted in Jeremiah chapter 37. These prophecies predict the conquest of Egypt by the Babylonians. Bible critics attempt to discredit the Bible by pointing out that there is little evidence that this conquest by Babylon against Egypt ever occurred. As discussed in the summary of Jeremiah, a clay tablet in the British Museum records: “In the 37th year of Nebuchadnezzar, king of the country of Babylon, he went to Mizrahim (Egypt) to wage war. Amasis, king of Egypt, collected [his army], and marched and spread abroad.” History records that afterward, Nebuchadnezzar returned to Babylon and built it up with canals, aqueducts, temples and reservoirs. Jeremiah says: “I will deliver them into the hand of those who seek

their life, into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon and his officers. Afterward Egypt shall be inhabited as in the days of old, declares the LORD” (VS. JER. 46:26). Egypt did retain her freedom “afterward” for about 60 years after Nebuchadnezzar’s campaign against it, until they were defeated by Cambyses II, king of Persia in 525 BC. This means that we do have evidence of fulfilment of this prophecy.

Z. Chapter 33 records how Ezekiel is appointed by the Lord as the watchman for Israel. A fugitive comes from Jerusalem reporting its destruction by Babylon.

AA. Chapter 34 metaphorically presents Israel as the Lord’s sheep. He rages against the evil shepherds, or Israel’s leaders, who were supposed to care for the sheep. The Lord says: “I will rescue my flock; they shall no longer be a prey. And I will judge between sheep and sheep. And I will set up over them one shepherd, my servant David, and he shall feed them: he shall feed them and be their shepherd. And I, the LORD, will be their God, and my servant David shall be prince among them. I am the LORD; I have spoken” (Vs.34: 22-24).

BB. Chapter 35 describes judgement against Mount Seir. This is a mountainous region originally given to Esau running along the eastern side of the Valley of Arabah from the dead Sea south to the Gulf of Aqaba. Today, it is located within the country of Jordan. Ezekiel repeats the word of the Lord to them: “Because you said, ‘These two nations and these two countries shall be mine, and we will take possession of them’—although the LORD was there—therefore, as I live, declares the Lord GOD, I will deal with you according to the anger and envy that you showed because of your hatred against them. And I will make myself known among them, when I judge you. And you shall know that I am the LORD” (VS. 35:10-12).

CC. Chapter 36 confirms God’s promise to bring back the scattered Jews to the land: “I will take you from the nations and gather you from all the countries and bring you into your own land. I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean from all your uncleanness, and from all your idols I will cleanse you. And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules. You shall dwell in the land that I gave to your fathers, and you shall be my people, and I will be your God” (Vs. 36:24-28).

DD. Chapter 37 is the valley of dry bones prophecy: “Therefore prophesy, and say to them, thus says the Lord GOD: ‘Behold, I will open your graves and raise you from your graves, O my people. And I will bring you into the land of Israel. And you shall know that I am the LORD, when I open your graves, and raise you from your graves, O my people. And I will put my Spirit within you, and you shall live, and I will place you in your own land. Then you shall know that I am the LORD; I have spoken, and I will do it, declares the LORD’” (Vs. 37:12-14).

EE. Chapters 38 and 39 tell of a war instigated by someone or some nation called Gog, of the land of Magog, the prince of Rosh, Meshech and Tubal (Vs. 38:2) and other nations including Persia, Cush, Put and Gomer. Much has been written about this war and there is much speculation as to when it occurs and who makes up the invading army. One viewpoint is that it is before the Great Tribulation, or even rapture of the church, as the weapons of the invading army are burned for seven years and burial of remains occurs for seven months (Vs. 39:9-10;12-16). Another viewpoint is that it begins during the first half of the tribulation as the invading army attacks when Israel is at peace (Vs. 38:8-11) which would be present during the Antichrist’s treaty with Israel. Gog will not win this war, but will be defeated by God Himself through a great earthquake (Vs. 38:19) and hail, fire and brimstone (Vs. 38:22). The result is that God will then be known: “Then they shall know that I am the LORD their God, because I sent them into exile among the nations and then assembled them into their own land. I will leave none of them remaining among the nations anymore. And I will not hide my face anymore from them, when I pour out my Spirit upon the house of Israel, declares the Lord GOD” (vs. 39:28-29).

FF. Chapters 40 through 48 detail an enormous temple including its dimensions and land assigned to the tribes, priests and the prince that will rule. It also presents various sacrifices and feasts that will be implemented. There are two schools of thought regarding the interpretation of what this means. One is that there will be a literal temple with literal feasts and sacrifices. Since Christ died on the Cross for all eternity, these must be used as a memorial to His accomplished work. The other viewpoint is that all of this is metaphorical. What argues against this viewpoint is the very detailed dimensions that are sufficient to construct such a temple. The consensus is that this will be during the Millennium period of 1,000 years after Christ returns.

GG. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. The description of the vision in chapter 1 has been used to attempt to say that Ezekiel saw an Unidentified Flying Object. From the detailed description of it, how would you argue against such a viewpoint?
2. The details of what happened to King Zedekiah, in that he would go to Babylon yet not see it (his eyes were put out) show the accuracy of Ezekiel's prophecies. Does this provide assurance that his other major prophecies will take place in the future?
3. How could you interpret the promise that God will put into his people: "a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules" (Vs. 11:16-20; 34:26-28). Does that New Covenant fulfill this promise? In what way?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)

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